SONYA SILVA

Research | Service Design | Strategy

ABOUT ME

Senior researcher, service designer, and strategy consultant with 15+ years of experience leading teams, research, and programmes in North America, the UK and Europe, East Africa, and South Asia for government, non-profit, and social impact clients. Specialised in participatory and trauma-informed research, and translating insights into innovative solutions to help build more equitable futures.

EXPERIENCE

Freelance Researcher, Strategist, and Consultant **May 2025 – Present**
Independent *Remote*

- Led multi-stakeholder research for US government clients to inform policy and service design.
- Contributed to the development of national licensing standards adopted by 26+ jurisdictions which was recognised with a global service design award. One state saved over $400,000 by updating their process, another recorded an 809% increase in licenses issued.

Senior User Experience Researcher **January 2024 – May 2025**
User Experience Researcher **October 2022 – January 2024**
Bloom Works *Remote*

- Designed and led mixed-methods research, including interviews, surveys, and co-design workshops with senior government officials, local experts, and partner organisations.
- Synthesised research findings into evidence-based recommendations for government leaders on working group coalitions, by creating process maps, reports, case studies, and presentations.

Researcher & Youth Policy Consultant **November 2021 – January 2022**
UN Department of Economic and Social Affairs (UN DESA) *Remote*

- Independently conducted policy research and synthesised emerging evidence in youth mental health, climate change, and peace and security, writing policy briefs for the UN youth team.

Service Designer & Researcher **May 2020 – September 2021**
The Traveling Diary Tour (volunteer role) *Remote*

- Designed a research plan and created surveys and interview guides to collect data and analyse user behaviours.
- Synthesised raw qualitative data into user flows, storyboards, user personas, affinity diagrams, emotion maps, and competitor analysis to communicate insights and support the growth of the project.

Engagement Manager **August 2019 – October 2022**
MLSE LaunchPad *Toronto, Canada*

- Managed a staff team of 5 and a $200K+ budget to develop and oversee a community engagement strategy, member services, and food and nutrition programmes in a youth sports for development organisation.
- Digitised food security and food skills programmes through home delivery of fresh food boxes to families, and by producing online cooking classes, while retaining $350K+ in sponsorship revenue.

Sri Lanka Operations Manager **February 2017 – October 2018**
SLV.Global *Western Province, Sri Lanka*

- Oversaw and standardised multi-site operations across 3 regional offices for a mental health organisation, including staffing and scheduling psychosocial support sessions at over 100 projects.
- Built the capacity of the operations department, including planning and onboarding 1,500 placements.

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Volunteer & Evaluation Coordinator **October 2013 – January 2017**
CRC (now amalgamated as Fred Victor) *Toronto, Canada*

- Researched best practices and designed a volunteer programme in a food security and housing organisation that increased participant engagement in volunteer roles from 13% to 35% in two years.
- Designed and facilitated training and events, and a user-friendly handbook for over 200 volunteers working with people experiencing homelessness, food insecurity, and mental health challenges.

Research Assistant **May 2013 – September 2013**
Toronto Cycling Think & Do Tank, University of Toronto *Toronto, Canada*

- Analysed how cycling is perceived in developing countries and its relevance for cycling uptake among Canadian newcomers to Toronto, which was published in a local online magazine, *Spacing*.
- Conducted comparative policy research and edited a report on cycling plans across 11 cities.

Monitoring & Evaluation Manager **April 2010 – June 2012**
Peace Child International *Buntingford, United Kingdom*

- Designed monitoring and evaluation frameworks, analysed data, and reported on a communication skills programme run with 600 students in the UK, and an international conference with 952 youth.
- Published training materials and facilitated international workshops and events for youth-led development organisations on sustainability, advocacy skills, and monitoring and evaluation.

Researcher **May 2009 – September 2009**
University of Toronto *Shinyanga, Tanzania*

- Designed and conducted an ethnographic research project in rural Tanzania, securing funding to investigate the lived experience of discrimination and barriers faced by people with albinism.
- Built relationships and trust with local partners to recruit participants, and conducted in-depth qualitative interviews and focus groups with community members, educators, medical staff, and government officials.

Programme Assistant **October 2007 – July 2008**
Presbyterian World Service & Development *Shinyanga, Tanzania*

- Designed and conducted participatory field research to identify barriers to engagement in a rural food security programme, using community mapping, wealth ranking, and qualitative interviews. This served as a mid-point evaluation and was published in a peer-reviewed journal.
- Built logic models, monitoring and evaluation frameworks, and wrote successful grant proposals securing $60K to $360K in multi-year funding for four new food security, water, school feeding, and HIV/AIDS programmes.

EDUCATION

Master of Arts, University of Toronto
Anthropology & Collaborative Programme in Women's Health

Honours Bachelor of Arts, University of Toronto
Specialist in International Development Studies and Major in Anthropology

SKILLS

Methods: Policy analysis and research, interviewing, surveys, participatory research, community engagement, co-design, usability testing, workshop facilitation, journey mapping, stakeholder mapping

Tools: Airtable, Coda, Notion, Figma, Miro, Mural, Otter, Grain, Dovetail, SurveyMonkey, Mailchimp, Google Workspace, MS Office

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